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BALANCING ASSESSMENTS: ESSAYS ON THEORIES



WRITTEN BY

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Foreword

The motivation behind this work exists for two reasons. First, we wanted our mentees to learn to think for themselves and recognize that they have a voice. Second, we wanted them to use the reading materials as evidence so that they develop the ability to organize information after group discussion. We wanted Dibyansh, Elvina, Upsana, and Mhigsang to explore new realms of writing, especially because writing assignments of this kind are not found in the National Education Board in Nepal. They sincerely put in work to write for the prompt, “Is it better to use Assessment for Learning, Assessment of Learning, or both if the country wants to have National Standards for English, Mathematics, and Science?” We hope that they shall produce essays, higher in rigour and eloquence, to take a stance on topics that matter the most to them.

May these essays reach the ears and hearts of those who have the power to shape education in Nepal. If anyone can get our Education Minister to read these essays, we will officially declare that person a superhero.

Enjoy reading!

Sincerely,

SHAPE Balapan team

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All four essays engage with Terry Crooks' "Assessment for Learning in the Accountability Era: New Zealand" (2011) and were written as part of the Shape Balapan Summer Program 2026 research track on rethinking assessment.

Finding Balance Amidst the Assessment Dilemma

By **Mhigshang Omo Lama Yolmo**

National Standards have become a major factor in many countries' attempts to assess students' academic achievements. These benchmarks clearly set out the expectations of students in the core subjects of English, Mathematics, and Science and the skills and knowledge that they will have acquired in each subject by the end of an academic year. However, as nations try to reach such a standard, they come across the dilemma between two major philosophies of assessment.

Assessment of Learning (AoL), often used interchangeably with summative assessment, revolves around judging, describing, and reporting a child's educational results at a specific time period to show the progress of the learner to stakeholders such as parents and the state. Assessment for Learning (AfL), on the other hand, is integrated into day-to-day teaching and learning. It draws on conversation, demonstration, guidance, and observation to shape what happens next in the classroom, rather than simply recording what already happened. Drawing on the insights of Terry Crooks from his paper *Assessment for learning in the accountability era: New Zealand*, this essay argues that a nation must utilize both assessment types to be successful. While National Standards provide necessary accountability, they cannot stand alone; a balanced system is required to ensure that the standardization necessary for national benchmarks does not undermine the individualized trust and feedback cycles essential for the progress of individual students.

Crooks identifies six validity conditions for AfL: (1) committed, motivated participants; (2) classroom trust; (3) clarity on goals, criteria, and standards; (4) appropriately challenging tasks; (5) student self-assessment capabilities; and

(6) actionable, insightful feedback (Crooks 73). This rare ideal requires alignment across the education system: one best illustrated by a small, highly resourced classroom of 15 students, where learners feel safe acknowledging their difficulties without fear of judgment. The teacher explains the learning goals and what good performance looks like. They give students challenging but manageable tasks and provide timely, specific feedback which is also monitored by guardians. Students then use self-assessment to review their work and make improvements before receiving a final grade.

In reality, however, this ideal faces severe structural friction in developing contexts like Nepal. Public school teachers often teach six or more classes each day, many of them filled with students. By the end of the day, they are often physically exhausted. Younger children can easily lose focus or interest, and financial pressures may make it difficult for parents to stay closely involved in their education. Expecting every classroom, such as those in Nepal, to hit all six validity conditions daily is unrealistic; instead, Crooks' conditions serve merely as aspirational benchmarks that educators might achieve gradually provided there are enough structural changes.

Learning does not happen in a straight line, and it looks different for every student, which is exactly why AfL has to be individualized to mean anything. Its validity depends on the student being an active participant, not a passive recipient of feedback handed down from above. A student has to actually take on the learning goal and do something about closing the gap in their own understanding. Teachers simply do not have the time to sit with every student individually, so a student who is not self-assessing tends to drift into passivity by default. This is why self-assessment, rooted in metacognition, or the practice of reflecting on one's own thinking, plays such an important role in sustained academic growth. The author emphasizes that developing students' metacognitive skills is both a valuable outcome of learning and a vital ingredient in the AfL process itself (Crooks 72). When students learn to check their own understanding, they become less dependent on teachers to point out when they are struggling. They can recognize problems, make adjustments, or ask for help when necessary. This skill is especially valuable in Nepalese classrooms, where large class sizes often mean students have to compete for a

teacher's attention.

AoL is chasing something different. Where AfL follows the individual's uneven path through learning, AoL exists to give a “trustworthy account” (Crooks 72) of what has been achieved over a set period. To do that, it needs to be standardized so that judgments hold up across different students and contexts. He sets out what that requires: the assessment must be relevant, fair regardless of background, and timed to come after students have had a real chance to act on formative feedback, not before (Crooks 72–73). The trouble starts when pressure from above pushes teachers to coach too narrowly toward the test itself, sometimes edging right up to giving away the answer. Crooks is blunt about the risk here: while supporting student understanding is meant to be the “prime function” of assessment, the current “accountability era” tilts the whole system toward high-stakes measurement (Crooks 73–75, 77). This pressure can compromise both a teacher's professional judgment and a student's genuine learning. In this condition, the validity measures of AfL become challenging to carry out. Hence, this tension between accountability and individual care needs attention from policy researchers to measure progress without compromising students' access to explorative learning with appropriate scaffolding.

For Crooks, the answer is not to pick a side but to find balance, so that neither summative nor formative assessment gets hollowed out at the other's expense. In practice, the two rarely stay cleanly separated anyway; teachers constantly rely on “headnoting,” the concept he borrowed from Marilyn F. Hill (Crooks 73). Headnoting are those unrecorded mental impressions built up through daily formative interaction, which then quietly feed into summative reports. This creates a real tension: leaning on informal classroom observation for formal reporting opens the door to bias, the halo effect of first impressions, confirmation bias or affinity bias toward students who happen to share a teacher's interests or temperament (Crooks 73). Based on my two years of classroom teaching experience, expecting an educator to evaluate students across an entire year without subjective bias is unrealistic, which is precisely why standardized AoL still earns its place in the system.

What is needed then is what Crooks calls a “carefully considered sequence of assessment activity”: formative support given early in the instructional cycle with summative evaluation saved for the end (73). When an assessment system breaks this order, or assigns grades to early practice tasks, students start focusing on the grades instead of learning from the diagnostic feedback. Crooks recommends breaking learning tasks into clear stages, giving specific feedback at each stage and letting students improve their work before a final grade is given. By making sure formative feedback comes before any judgment, national standards can meet public demands for accountability without weakening genuine student learning.

In essence, Assessment for Learning (AfL) and Assessment of Learning (AoL), rather than clashing as completely different concepts, are best understood when they complement one another. While final evaluations satisfy the public demand for school accountability, ongoing classroom feedback ensures that teaching and learning continuously improve. Evidently, effective educational policy requires a shift from the ‘one-size-fits-all’ concept to a multi-dimensional and balanced idea.

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Contextual Imitation from New Zealand to Nepal

By **Upsana Thapa**

National standards define what students should know and be able to do by a certain grade level and age through formal schooling. To check whether those standards have been achieved, an assessment is needed. Mainly, there are two types of assessment: AoL and AfL. The purpose of Assessment of Learning (AoL) is to test knowledge after a specific time interval, whereas Assessment for Learning (AfL) aims to improve learning on the spot by giving feedback while teaching. The country needs evidence of achievement, yet when measurement becomes the primary focus, it can distort what happens in the classroom. Consequently, while both approaches are essential, they must be applied for different reasons and at the appropriate moments.

Once national standards are set, AoL is needed because it gives data on how much students have learned in specific time periods. AoL should be standardized since the assessment operates at the national scale; it would be unfair if it were individualized, since students would be assessed under different conditions like different questions, different marking, and different expectations. But having a standardized assessment isn't enough; it needs to actually measure what it claims to measure. If I want to check the ability of students to solve maths problems, it wouldn't be valid to make questions with difficult vocabulary, as it is testing the vocabulary of students, not only maths. Therefore, to check whether the national standard has been achieved, the assessment must judge only the target skill, free from external factors.

While AoL measures how much students have learned, AfL is what actually helps them learn better. AfL happens during learning, so it helps the teacher identify difficulties students face, provide instant feedback, and make an

assistance method that will be most suitable for a specific pupil. AfL can therefore support improvement before final judgment. Crooks (2011) finds that students often pay less attention to specific feedback when marks/grades are also provided. Similarly, the Education Review Office (2018) found that effective schools provided students with opportunities to practise new skills and gave them targeted feedback related to their learning goals. This suggests that feedback is valuable and treated as primary only when students are given time to act on it and see a reason to do so.

There is, however, a tension when AoL becomes closely tied to accountability. In order to be accountable, schools focus heavily on assessment results; direct or indirect pressure is placed on respective subject teachers and schools, creating incentives that encourage teaching to the test. To score high, students will be driven towards rote learning, and studies will be more exam-oriented (narrowed curriculum) than interest and exploration. Crooks (2011) warns that students may meet the tested standard without gaining the broader learning the standard is intended to represent.

The consequences of this pressure are evident in Nepal's own examination system. The SEE has become a life-defining event, creating immense psychological pressure. Following the publication of SEE results each year, it is common to hear reports of hardship among students who receive poor results (Shrestha, 2025, para. 3). The pressure has also led to widespread exam malpractice. In Sunsari district, invigilators were caught helping students cheat through WhatsApp groups during the mathematics exam, leading to arrests and expulsions (The Rising Nepal, 2025, para. 6). Furthermore, a Grade 10 student writing in The Rising Nepal admitted that cheating has become a survival mechanism because the system has made students believe their success is determined solely by test performance (Dhungana, 2025, para. 3). These examples demonstrate that when accountability metrics become the primary goal, the broader purpose of education is undermined.

A good national assessment system should not only tell a country how much students have learned, but should also support how students can learn better. This principle is supported by Black et al. (2004), who conducted a

study with secondary school teachers and found that improving the quality of classroom assessment, focusing feedback on how to improve rather than on grades, significantly enhances student learning. Their research demonstrates that when assessment is used as a tool for learning, it directly supports how students can learn better, rather than simply measuring what they have learned.

I recommend both assessments because they serve different purposes. Crooks says no single assessment can be timed to serve both purposes well. AfL needs to happen early enough for students to act on feedback, while AoL should come later, after opportunities for improvement. A well-designed system ensures that assessments are standardized and valid, timed appropriately so that AfL can guide instruction and AoL can measure outcomes. But none of this works if accountability pressures distort teaching. The system must resist the urge to turn measurement into a target.

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Learning before Labeling: Rethinking National

By Elvina Baral

Some nations consider national standards for English, Mathematics and Science to be necessary because they set a standard on what students must know and should be able to do by the end of an academic year. In order to measure whether these expectations have been met, assessments are important. However, the type of assessment used to measure students' learning changes how students learn. This essay argues that both Assessment for Learning and Assessment of Learning are crucial for a holistic development, but AfL should form the foundation of the system, while AoL should be used primarily for accountability and monitoring.

When implementation of AoL is largely prioritized over AfL, students become aware that their performance is being compared to others, and it can weaken the trust that Assessment for Learning depends on. In the paper Crooks mentions that it had become common practice for regional newspapers to publish tables showing NCEA results for all secondary schools in their region (Crooks 76). Because of this, students became more aware of normative comparisons, which compromised the conditions needed for effective Assessment for Learning. Crooks also notes that trust is important for AfL because students need to feel safe admitting that they are unsure or do not understand something in order to ask for help (Crooks 76). If students feel that assessment is mainly about comparison and performance, they may become less willing to show their weaknesses and instead focus on how they are performing compared to others.

Also, when AoL dominates without AfL, schools may discourage weaker students from attempting certain standardized tests in order to protect their

results and rankings. The author explains that schools that are very conscious of their accountability for results, may discourage students who seem weaker from attempting certain qualifications so that a higher percentage of students who do attempt tests succeed (Crooks 76). Schools may also guide students away from subjects or particular standards that appear more difficult to pass. Although this may improve a school's results, it can limit students' future academic options. Crooks argues that focusing on prescribed achievement standards can lead schools to prioritize whether students meet particular benchmarks rather than whether they are making meaningful progress (Crooks 75). This shows how strong accountability pressure can shift the focus of assessment away from helping students learn and towards protecting a school's performance.

However, AoL itself is not the problem, because even after a solid AfL is developed, AoL still has an important purpose, as schools and countries need to know whether students are meeting the same national expectations. Crooks therefore emphasizes that the two forms of assessment serve distinct but complementary purposes. AfL supports learning by providing feedback that students can act on. On the other hand, AoL provides evidence of achievement after students have had sufficient opportunities to learn and respond to feedback. This suggests that national assessment systems should not treat AfL and AoL as competing approaches, but should position them at different stages of the learning process. National Standards can then measure achievement without allowing the demands of final assessment to dominate the learning process itself.

Overall, both AfL and AoL have an important role in a national assessment system, but they should not be treated as the same thing. Crooks' discussion of New Zealand shows that when accountability becomes the dominant part of assessment, it can affect both students and schools in ways that undermine AfL. Students may become more concerned with how their performance compares with others, while schools may prioritize protecting their results over giving all students opportunities to learn and demonstrate their abilities. These pressures can weaken the trust, feedback, and willingness to take risks that AfL depends on. Therefore, AfL should form the foundation of the assessment system,

allowing assessment to support learning before achievement is formally measured. AoL can then be used to determine whether students are meeting National Standards and to provide evidence for accountability, but it should not create pressures that work against the learning process.

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Accountability to the Students' Future

By Dibyansh Shah

When a country wants to create national standards for English, Mathematics, or Science, it needs to know whether students are actually learning or not and whether they are reaching the expected level or not. This creates a debate about whether the country should mainly use Assessment for Learning (AfL) or Assessment of Learning (AoL). In my view, a country should use both, but AfL should have the greater role in everyday classroom learning. AoL is necessary, as National Standards need common evidence of achievement, but too much focus or emphasis on it can create accountability pressure and move teachers away from actually helping students learn.

AfL should be at the centre of classroom teaching because its purpose is to improve learning while students are learning. Crooks explains that assessment for learning uses information from things such as dialogue, demonstrations and observations to improve the concept and ongoing learning (Crooks 71–72). For example, if a student is struggling with geometry, a teacher can notice the problem and then explain it with demonstrations and even give feedback; in this process the teacher may even change the way the topic is taught before the final assessment. AfL also connects with Assessment as Learning, where students monitor their own progress and develop metacognition and self-regulation (Crooks 71). This means assessment is not simply telling students whether they are good or bad, instead it helps them understand what they need to improve. In this way it leads to progression towards having formative assessment rather than summative assessment. There is also evidence from New Zealand that this approach can work in practice. The Education Review Office found that effective schools used assessment information to give feedback, identify students needing support or extension, and set goals

with students. This shows that assessment information can be used as an ongoing tool for improving learning, rather than simply being used to produce a final grade (Education Review Office).

However, assessment of learning remains vital in a country if it is serious about implementing national standards. The government also needs a reliable way to assess their students in the country. Crooks in his writing also says in an explaining way that AoL aims to deliver a “trustworthy” measure of student achievement, ensuring consistency and accountability in education (Crooks 72). This makes some standardization necessary. Without AoL, seeing the outcome or even comparing achievement would become much more difficult.

One major problem appears when accountability pressures become too strong. This is where I think Crooks' argument is particularly convincing. When schools have to prove that students are meeting national standards, teachers may feel pressure to use more formal and standardized assessments. The danger is that teachers could begin to focus more on producing evidence for the government or parents than on responding to individual students. In fact, Crooks makes the important distinction that Assessment of Learning should be standardised, whereas Assessment for Learning should be individualised (Crooks 73–74).

This does not mean that accountability is always harmful, though. In fact, the New Zealand experience gives us an interesting example of how the two purposes can exist together even though there is incomplete research on the dual use of assessments (Crooks 73). According to Crooks, the ERO states that assessment and evaluation in New Zealand inform both improvement and accountability, while placing a strong emphasis on improvement, teacher professionalism, student responsibility and responding to diverse learner needs. He used National Certificates of Educational Achievement to give a brief historical account, which relates to proving my point as well. The idea put forward explained that assessment does not necessarily have to be used only to produce a final result (Crooks 75). Assessment information can also provide evidence of how two purposes can exist together and also help us understand what students have achieved while helping teachers and students identify areas

for further improvement. This supports the idea that the two purposes of assessment can exist together.

An important issue is assessment validity. Crooks argues that AoL needs to consider relevance, sampling, timing, fairness and coherence (Crooks 72). An assessment should actually measure what it claims to measure. If a science test is supposed to measure scientific understanding but mainly tests complicated reading skills, it may not give a valid picture of a student's science ability. So, AfL also needs to go hand in hand and be used properly. Crooks highlights the importance of trust, clear goals, self-assessment, and effective feedback. Therefore, neither type of assessment is automatically effective just because it has the right label. For example, if my teacher gives me a quiz as a way of formative assessment, but if the teacher only gives us a score without explaining our mistakes or giving us a chance to improve, the quiz does not really support learning. In contrast, when the teacher discusses our mistakes, gives clear feedback and allows us to use that feedback, the same assessment becomes much more useful for learning. This shows that the way assessment is used is just as important as whether it is called AfL or AoL.

Overall, I believe both Assessment for Learning and Assessment of Learning should be used, but they should not have exactly the same purpose. AoL is necessary because national standards require some form of common, reliable and comparable evidence of achievement. AfL, however, should remain the foundation of everyday classroom assessment because it is the process that helps students understand their learning, respond to feedback and improve. A good national system should therefore use AoL to show where students are while using AfL to help students understand where they need to go and how to get there.

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